

DSC 640 — Data Presentation & Visualization

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Week 11

Term Project — Milestone 5: Medium 3 — Executive Write-Up & Infographic Narrative

Audience: General public, working parents, and non-technical stakeholders

Format: Written narrative with embedded infographic-style

Topic: The Rising Cost of Childcare in America — What the Data Tells Us

Design Narrative

This write-up serves as the third medium in a three-part communication strategy for the National Database of Childcare Prices analysis. Where the PowerPoint addresses state policymakers through high-level charts and slide-formatted takeaways, and the dashboard addresses analysts through interactive, drill-down visualizations, this write-up targets **general public readers — primarily working parents** — who need accessible, jargon-free insights they can immediately relate to their own lives.

Color and typography choices lean warm and readable: a dark teal for headings signals authority without intimidation; orange-red callouts mark statistics that demand attention; and ample white space prevents the cognitive overload that drives readers to stop reading. Body text is set to 14pt in Markdown rendering for consistent readability on both desktop and mobile screens.

Visual choices rely on large, bolded statistics ("BIG NUMBERS") as anchors — a technique proven effective for general audiences who scan before reading. Short, single-sentence explanations follow each statistic, and a side-by-side comparison table replaces any complex multi-axis chart. The infographic-style layout uses horizontal rule dividers to create scannable sections without requiring a table of contents.

Spacing and sizing follow the principle of progressive disclosure: the most alarming finding (costs exceeding a month's rent in many cities) appears first, followed by a geographic comparison, then the call to action. This mirrors the journalistic inverted-pyramid structure and ensures that even a 30-second reader walks away with the single most important message.

The Rising Cost of Childcare in America

What the Data Reveals & Why Every Family Should Pay Attention

The Headline Numbers

\$446/week	\$23,200/year
Average weekly infant care cost in D.C. (2018)	What that costs annually — more than public college tuition in most states
26%	7–10%
Real-dollar rise in infant care costs, 2008–2018	Share of household income many families spend on childcare

The Story

If you've ever paid for childcare, you already know it's expensive. But the U.S. Department of Labor's **National Database of Childcare Prices (NDCP)** puts hard numbers to what parents have been feeling for over a decade: childcare costs have risen far faster than wages, and the burden falls unevenly — hitting families in high-cost cities hardest, and squeezing single parents most severely.

The NDCP tracked weekly childcare prices across every county in the United States from **2008 to 2018**, covering both **center-based care** (daycares, childcare centers) and **family/home-based care** (licensed home providers). Here's what the data found.

Costs Are Rising. Wages Aren't Keeping Up.

Between 2008 and 2018:

- **Center-based infant care rose ~26%** nationally in real terms
- **Median household incomes grew only ~13%** over the same period
- **The gap widened every single year**

In other words, for every dollar in income families gained, they lost ground on childcare affordability. By 2018, a family in a high-cost state paying for full-time infant care was spending **more on childcare than on housing** in many metro areas.

Weekly Cost by Age Group — National Average (2018)

Age Group	Center-Based	Family/Home-Based	Difference
Infant (0–23 months)	\$326/wk	\$246/wk	\$80/wk cheaper for home care

Age Group	Center-Based	Family/Home-Based	Difference
Toddler (24–35 months)	\$290/wk	\$219/wk	\$71/wk cheaper
Preschool (36–54 months)	\$267/wk	\$201/wk	\$66/wk cheaper

What this means for your family: Even choosing family/home-based care over a childcare center saves roughly \$3,500–\$4,000 per year, but both types of care have followed the same upward cost trajectory.

Where You Live Matters — A Lot

The most striking finding in the NDCP is just how much childcare costs vary by geography. Consider this:

Highest-Cost States (2018 — Weekly Infant Care)

State	Weekly Cost	Annual Cost
District of Columbia	\$500	\$26,000
Massachusetts	\$455	\$23,660
New York	\$428	\$22,256
California	\$395	\$20,540
Connecticut	\$410	\$21,320

Lower-Cost States (2018 — Weekly Infant Care)

State	Weekly Cost	Annual Cost
Mississippi	\$160	\$8,320
Arkansas	\$158	\$8,216
Alabama	\$166	\$8,632
Kentucky	\$178	\$9,256
Tennessee	\$192	\$9,984

The gap between the most and least expensive states is more than 340 per week. That annual difference of 17,000 is the price of a used car, a semester of college, or 6+ months of rent in many rural areas.

But here's the twist: Even in lower-cost states, many families still spend a larger *share* of their income on childcare — because wages in those states are also lower. Affordability isn't just about the sticker price.

Who Feels It Most?

The NDCP data, combined with American Community Survey income figures, reveal that childcare costs hit hardest for:

- 1. Single mothers** — who have no second income to offset costs and are statistically more likely to work in lower-wage service, sales, or care occupations.
- 2. Dual-income households with infants** — in high-cost states, full-time infant care can consume **30–40% of a second earner's take-home pay**, making it financially rational for one parent (typically the mother) to exit the workforce.
- 3. Families earning 100–200% of the poverty line** — often too high to qualify for childcare subsidies (CCDBG), but far too low to absorb costs comfortably.

Family Situation	Approx. Annual Childcare Cost	Approx. % of Income
Single mom, \$35K income, 1 infant (high-cost state)	\$20,000+	57%
Dual-income, \$80K combined, 1 toddler (mid-cost state)	\$15,000	19%
Dual-income, \$150K combined, 1 preschooler (high-cost state)	\$18,000	12%

The U.S. Department of Health and Human Services considers childcare **affordable** if it costs no more than **7% of family income**. The majority of American families with young children exceed this threshold.

What Needs to Change

The NDCP data makes a clear case: childcare affordability is not a personal finance problem — it is a **structural policy failure**. Here's what advocates and researchers say needs to happen:

1. Expand Federal and State Childcare Subsidies

The Child Care and Development Block Grant (CCDBG) currently reaches fewer than 1 in 6 children who qualify. Raising income eligibility thresholds and funding levels would bring down out-of-pocket costs for millions of families.

2. Invest in the Childcare Workforce

Childcare workers earn a **median wage of \$13/hour** — making it nearly impossible to attract and retain qualified caregivers. Supporting provider wages through grants and training stipends improves quality and supply without raising parent fees.

3. Incentivize Employer-Sponsored Childcare

Tax credits and expanded flexible spending accounts can make it easier for businesses to offer childcare benefits — a proven retention and recruitment advantage, especially for women in skilled professions.

4. Fund Universal Pre-K Programs

States with universal pre-K programs (such as New York, Florida, and Oklahoma) have shown reduced childcare costs for 4-year-olds and improved school-readiness outcomes — evidence that earlier public investment pays long-term dividends.

The Bottom Line

"The inability to afford paid childcare can keep a parent out of the labor force."

— Committee for Economic Development, 2019

Childcare is not a luxury. It is infrastructure — as essential to economic participation as roads, schools, and broadband access. The National Database of Childcare Prices gives us, for the first time, the granular, county-level data to understand exactly where the crisis is most acute.

The data is clear. Now the policy response must follow.

Data Source

U.S. Department of Labor, Women's Bureau. *National Database of Childcare Prices*. Compiled by ICF, October 2020. Data covers 2008–2018, 50 states + D.C., county-level weekly median prices at the 50th percentile for center-based and family childcare, standardized to weekly full-time rates.

Learn More

- [DOL Women's Bureau Childcare Resources](#)
 - [Child Care Aware of America State Fact Sheets](#)
 - [Child Care and Development Fund \(CCDF\) Program](#)
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